

“Shawn was playing 12 hours a day, and he wasn’t supposed to because he was epileptic, and the game would cause seizures,” she said. “Probably the last eight times he had seizures were because of stints on the computer.”

Woolley knows her son had problems beyond *EverQuest*, and she tried to get him help by contacting a mental health program and trying to get him to live in a group home. A psychologist diagnosed him with depression and schizoid personality disorder, symptoms of which include a lack of desire for social relationships, little or no sex drive and a limited range of emotions in social settings.

“This fed right into the *EverQuest* playing,” Woolley said. “It was the perfect escape.”

Jay Parker, a chemical dependency counsellor and co-founder of Internet/Computer Addiction Services in Redmond, Washington, said Woolley’s mental health problems put him in a category of people more likely to be at risk of getting addicted to online games.

Parker said people who are isolated, prone to boredom and lonely are much more susceptible to becoming addicted to online games. Having low self-esteem or poor body image are also important factors, he said.

“The manufacturer of *EverQuest* purposely made it in such a way that it is more intriguing to the addict,” Parker said. “It could be created in a less addictive way, but (that) would be the difference between powdered cocaine and crack cocaine.”

Parker doesn’t make the narcotics analogy lightly. One client—a 21-year-old college student—stopped going to class within eight weeks after he started playing *EverQuest* his senior year.

After playing the game for 36 hours straight, he had a psy-